

Grassroots to glory: KRAFTON's blueprint for Indian esports

KRAFTON's roadmap has **two key agendas:** sustaining a robust ecosystem and building a clear pipeline for future talent.

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An esports tournament — Battlegrounds Mobile India Series (BGIS) 2026 in Chennai last month — smashed viewership records, as over half a million people watched the tournament concurrently.

Esports, now recognised by the World Anti-Doping Agency and played in Asian and Commonwealth Games, is no longer a mere distraction. And KRAFTON — which owns Battlegrounds Mobile India (BGMI) — is among those who have defined that narrative.

"When we initially arrived in India, we were trying to build through the grassroots — create opportunities for people to come join us," Karan Pathak

(pic, left), Associate Director — Esports at KRAFTON India, told *Sportstar* on the sidelines of BGIS.

"Initially, it was just gaming and nothing else. But from 2023, when the offline LAN events started off,

people understood that it was more than just the game."

At the Battlegrounds Mobile India Pro Series 2023 in Ahmedabad, Pathak remembers a packed crowd of 27,000 people.

"Parents got validation. They understood that esports was not just about playing games. Nodwin, Tesseract and Skyesports — all of these guys started posting job opportunities like us," he added.

KRAFTON and Pathak have not had to look back since.

"The first event that we did, we had around 200 people working on it. Today, we have about 2-3,000 people who have worked on BGIS," Pathak noted.

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"Previously, tournaments led to nothing else. From 2024, (we ensured that players) went from BGIS to the Pro Series. We had the BMIC, and we recruited players for the Pro Series from third-party tournaments," he explained.

"Once the ecosystem got linked, the viewership increased because they knew these players were not going anywhere for the next six months."

For talent recruitment, KRAFTON has college tournaments and the Rising Stars programme in its plans.

"We have learned that if there is sufficient support and the right direction given by industry experts, these individuals can make a lot of progress," Pathak added.

"The Rising Stars from the first cohort have become famous in their locality. The second cohort will have a huge impact, too. Like Noobpari_ (Paridhi Gupta), who was in the first cohort. She felt nobody was watching. And I said we are watching, and look at her now (she has over 200,000 followers/subscribers across social media platforms)."

But is there room for improvement?

"Yes," Pathak said, "We need better coaches, better strategists, and analysts. There are a bunch of them in the country right now, but we need more."

"We've made a lot of progress compared to 2021 to now in 2026. Previously, we would not even qualify for a global event. We are among the title contenders now. With more access to equipment than we have now, I believe we will make it bigger."

